



Housing Associations: The Untapped Engine for Employment, Skills and Social Mobility

The UK's housing associations have long been recognised as providers of safe, affordable homes. However, their role extends far beyond bricks and mortar. As anchor institutions rooted in their communities, housing associations are uniquely placed to tackle some of society's most persistent challenges, including unemployment, skills shortages and economic inactivity.

At a time when the Government is focused on economic growth, reducing inactivity and improving opportunities for disadvantaged communities, there has never been a stronger case for housing associations to work hand-in-hand with employment and skills providers.

Housing Is More Than a Home

A secure home provides the foundation for stability, but stability alone does not create prosperity. Many housing association tenants face complex barriers to employment, including poor mental health, low confidence, limited qualifications, caring responsibilities, financial hardship and digital exclusion.

Without coordinated support, these barriers can prevent individuals from accessing work, progressing their careers or participating fully in society.

Housing associations often have trusted relationships with residents that some employment services may struggle to establish. This makes them ideal partners for identifying needs early and connecting people with appropriate support.

A Shared Mission

Employment and skills providers bring expertise in careers advice, vocational training, apprenticeships, employability programmes and employer engagement. Housing associations bring trusted community relationships, local knowledge and direct access to residents.

Together, these organisations can create genuinely person-centred services that improve outcomes for individuals while strengthening local economies.



Partnerships can deliver:

- ✓ Better access to employment support.
- ✓ Increased participation in adult learning and skills programmes.
- ✓ Higher apprenticeship uptake.
- ✓ Improved financial resilience.
- ✓ Reduced dependency on welfare.
- ✓ Better health and wellbeing outcomes.
- ✓ Stronger, more resilient communities.

Supporting Government Priorities

The Government's ambition to increase employment and boost economic growth cannot be achieved by employment services alone.

Many economically inactive people live in social housing. By embedding employment and skills support within housing communities, housing associations become critical delivery partners for national priorities including:

- Reducing economic inactivity.
- Improving productivity.
- Tackling child poverty.
- Supporting the Youth Guarantee.
- Delivering Local Growth Plans.
- Closing regional inequalities.

This is particularly important as devolved authorities and local partnerships increasingly commission integrated services.

Prevention Rather Than Crisis

Too often, support is provided only after someone has reached crisis point. Imagine instead if every housing association offered residents proactive careers advice, digital skills support, financial coaching and links to local employers from the moment they signed their tenancy.

Early intervention can prevent long-term unemployment, improve household income and reduce demand on public services. The return on investment extends well beyond employment outcomes. Increased incomes improve rent collection, reduce arrears, strengthen tenancy sustainment and contribute to healthier communities.



The Power of Collaboration

Successful partnerships require more than referrals. Housing associations and employment providers should jointly design services, share intelligence, co-locate staff where possible and measure success using shared outcomes rather than organisational targets.

Collaboration should also include employers, colleges, local authorities, voluntary organisations and health partners to create a seamless support system around residents.

Looking Ahead

The future of social housing is not simply about providing homes—it is about creating opportunities.

Housing associations have an opportunity to become catalysts for economic inclusion, helping residents build sustainable careers while contributing to local and national growth.

Employment and skills providers, meanwhile, gain access to trusted community networks and individuals who might otherwise remain disengaged.

When housing, employment and skills come together, the result is far greater than the sum of their parts. Communities become stronger, employers gain access to local talent, public services achieve better value for money, and residents are empowered not just to live well, but to thrive.

As the UK continues to reshape its employment and skills landscape, collaboration between housing associations and employment providers should no longer be viewed as an optional extra. It should be recognised as an essential component of inclusive growth and long-term community prosperity

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